all these years

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31398668.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by harrowhark

Summary

'Catra looks at her, beautiful blue and yellow eyes bearing right into Adora's soul. Her tail moves and curls around Adora's waist, and her ears are folded back shyly when she nods. "Yeah. I think forever sounds nice with you."

Adora realises, up on that ledge when she's six years old, that there's nobody else she'd want to spend forever with.'

Or, five times Adora realises she's always loved Catra and the one time she realises that Catra has always loved her too.

Notes

this is another one of those fics where i sorta got possessed, wrote it, proof read it in the space of 5 hours and now can no longer look at it so here you go it's yours now enjoy

See the end of the work for more notes

1)

The first time Adora realises her feelings for Catra are something *different*, she's six.

They've both just started their cadet training, learning basic fighting manoeuvrers and strategy planning. Adora doesn't understand a lot of it yet – she just knows that the princesses are evil, and that the Horde are fighting them. One day, Adora will be part of that fight.

Catra will be too. Adora thinks she understands even less. At this age, Catra still gets distracted by little things. Even her own tail – it drifts into her peripheral vision and she whirls around like there's prey she needs to pounce on. Shadow Weaver thinks it makes her stupid, but Adora just thinks it's cute.

Shadow Weaver still lets them have weekends off. All week, she teaches them the basics, reprimands them if they get things wrong – usually reprimands *Catra* – but their weekends are still theirs. It'll be different when they're older, when they're *real* soldiers. They're not supposed to play, because they're not little kids anymore, but they still do. Mostly, they spend their weekends running around, hiding, playing tricks on the other kids like Kyle.

Weekends are Adora's favourite, because she always spends them with Catra.

"I can't reach up there!"

Catra cackles from where she's perched up on a high beam. She's staring down at Adora triumphantly, tail flicking playfully behind her. "That's because you're the worst climber in the world."

"I am *not*," Adora takes a few steps back and tries to grab onto the beam at a run. She falls short and lands heavily on the cold metal floor. She knows she's scraped her knee, but scrapes are nothing to a soldier. Pain makes you strong, that's what Shadow Weaver says.

She hears the light rake of claws against the floor, and suddenly Catra lands on her chest, blue and yellow eyes peering down at her reproachfully. "Are you okay? You wiped out pretty hard."

Adora scoffs. "I did *not*! I just didn't realise how far it was."

Catra smiles, tiny fang poking out over a soft lip. "Sure, dummy. Come on, I'll give you a piggyback ride. We can see how high up we can get."

Catra turns around, tail swishing playfully, waiting for Adora to jump onto her back. Adora sits up and leans forwards, letting her fingers sink into soft fur as she wraps her arms around Catra's shoulders.

"Hold on tight," Catra says before she makes the first jump up, and Adora buries her face into her fur and clings on for dear life. "Shadow Weaver will kill me if you fall."

She's a little terrified, and Adora knows that a good soldier isn't supposed to show fear. But around Catra… maybe she doesn't have to be a good soldier. Maybe Adora can just be *Adora*.

"Whoa," Catra's voice snaps Adora back to attention, and she peeks out from her hiding place in Catra's shoulder. They're high up, way higher than Adora thinks she could ever climb, and the whole Fright Zone is right there, sprawled out ahead of them. "Look at it."

"It's like the whole world," Adora says over Catra's shoulder. She looks down and instantly regrets it. There's a small platform that they're standing on, but behind them is a big plunge into the smoky abyss below. She gulps and hides her face back in Catra's shoulder. "Don't drop me."

"I'd never drop you," Catra says, and Adora's stomach does a weird jumpy thing that she doesn't understand. Catra moves forwards, claws scraping against metal, and then she stops. "You can let go now."

Adora realises that she doesn't want to let go. Catra's fur is soft and warm, and she likes to be close to her best friend. But slowly, she peels herself away and sits down on the ledge next to Catra. Adora settles for gripping Catra's arm when she realises just how high up they are. She knows that Catra won't let her fall.

"One day, we're going to rule it all," Catra says, tail flicking playfully as she stares out at the Fright Zone, "you and me. Just like it's always supposed to be."

"We'll make the world a better place, just like Lord Hordak wants," Adora agrees, shuffling closer to Catra. Her grip on Catra's arm tightens, because Adora's not sure she likes being this high. It's a really long fall, and she's clumsy sometimes. "Do you really want to stay with me forever, though? That's a long time."

Catra looks at her, beautiful blue and yellow eyes bearing right into Adora's soul. Her tail moves and curls around Adora's waist, and her ears are folded back shyly when she nods. "Yeah. I think forever sounds nice with you."

Adora realises, up on that ledge when she's six years old, that there's nobody else she'd want to spend forever with.

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2)

Obviously, Adora knows that Catra looks different to the other cadets in the Horde.

The other cadets don't have a big fluffy tail, or pointy ears, or soft fur you can run your hands through. They're all like Adora, with smooth skin and round ears and no tail. If they're not like Adora, they're lizards like Rogelio.

There aren't any other people like Catra, though.

Adora always thought it was cool. Not just because Catra is special, but because her ears and her tail help Adora know how Catra is feeling. She moves them in certain ways, and even if

she’s saying one thing, sometimes she moves her tail and Adora knows she means another.

Catra never seemed to notice she was different until they’re eight and kids start to get mean. Adora knows that she must’ve known on some level, but she never thought anything different until then.

Adora finds her one day, curled up in fear, while some older cadets laugh at her, poke at her and pull on her ears and her tail. She knows how much that hurts Catra, because she’d told her just how sensitive her ears and her tail are to touch when Adora accidentally stepped on it one time.

That’s why it makes her so mad.

Adora runs full speed at the cadets with a loud, “*hey!”*

There’s four of them, and they’re at least three years older and a lot taller than Adora. But she doesn’t care. Catra is scared, so Adora is going to be a good soldier and fight for what she believes in. And she believes in Catra. She’ll always believe in Catra.

The tallest one laughs right in her face, and then looks back to a scared, quivering Catra on the ground. “And who is this? Your owner?”

Catra looks at Adora, and her tail *thwacks* against the ground once. Maybe it’s a natural instinct that she can’t hold back, but the cadet laughs. “Aw, is the little kitty happy to see her owner?”

“I’m not her owner, I’m her best friend,” Adora stamps her foot on the ground and shoves into the cadet. “You leave her alone. Why don’t you pick on someone your own size?”

“Why don’t you pick someone from the same species?” One of the other cadets say, shoving her to the ground. “Then again, maybe the two freaks should stick together.”

“Look at that, she’s protective of her little pet,” Another cadet laughs, shoving Adora to the ground again as she tries to get up. Catra lets out a quiet hiss, and the boy laughs. “Is that supposed to be scary, kitty?”

The boy laughs, but when he goes to shove Adora again, Catra’s claws are ready. He’s not laughing anymore when there are four long gashes in his hand. Catra darts away, and Adora realises their opening and chases after her, but she goes at a snail’s pace compared to Catra when she’s running on all fours.

Adora soon loses sight of her, but thankfully the cadets aren’t following either, so she slows down and takes a minute to get her breath back. She knows where Catra goes to hide, and she knows that Catra knows, so she makes her way to the old storage room and calls for her.

“Catra?”

Adora knows she’s here. It’s like a part of her can *feel* Catra. She doesn’t know what it is, but she likes it. She likes feeling her best friend’s presence.

There’s a few shuffles and a scrape behind one of the crates, and Adora smiles. “There you are. Are you okay?”

There’s a flick of a tail behind the box, and it thumps against the cold metal floor again. Adora peers around the crate just as Catra hides her face in her knees. The big crate is heavy to move, and it makes a horrible grinding noise as she pushes it that makes Catra’s fur stand on end. Adora is quick to smooth it down with a hand as she plops down on the floor next to her with a big gap-toothed smile. Catra unfurls slightly, if only to fix Adora with a warning glare.

“Hi,” Adora says, undeterred from the angry glare on Catra’s face. She reaches out and gently scratches behind Catra’s ear, and Catra almost chokes on the purr she tries to stifle. Adora doesn’t like it when she does that. She loves hearing Catra’s purrs, feeling

the rumble of it against her chest. “Are you alright, Catra? Those kids were mean.”

Catra pulls away and scoots around so Adora is left facing her back. She huddles into herself again and Adora can’t understand why she’s being like this. Adora had helped her, she’d saved her from the bullies. And it’s not like Shadow Weaver will find out that Catra used her claws; an older cadet isn’t going to cry to Shadow Weaver that an eight year old girl had beaten them.

Adora reaches out again, and Catra lets out a warning hiss, her mane fluffing up in an effort to make herself bigger. It doesn’t work; by all definitions, Catra is still only just a kitten, and Adora knows she’d never hurt her anyway.

“Catra…” Adora doesn’t let the hiss deter her. Her fingers run gently through Catra’s mane, smoothing it back down and soothing Catra in the process. “What’s wrong? Did I… did I do something wrong?”

Slowly, Adora shuffles closer, so her front is pressed up against Catra’s back. Little arms wrap around her in a hold that Adora knows Shadow Weaver would punish them for, but she can’t bring herself to stop. She doesn’t understand the feeling just yet.

“You didn’t,” Catra whispers, so quietly that Adora has to strain to hear. “You never do anything wrong.”

“Is it…” Adora pauses, her grip tightening around Catra, “is it what those older cadets said to you?”

Catra shakes her head, and Adora is even more confused. Why would she be upset, then?

“I don’t like being different,” Catra says, tail curling around herself, “people laugh, and they’re mean, and they pull on my tail and scream in my ears until it hurts.”

“Oh, Catra,” Adora scoots closer, pressing into Catra’s back, “It’s not your fault that the other cadets are big meanies.”

"Sometimes I want to run away," Catra admits, and Adora is scared *for* her. It's forbidden to even consider defecting, and if Shadow Weaver knew... Adora doesn't know what she'd do. It'd be a bad punishment, for sure. "I want to find other people like me. I know that- I know that Shadow Weaver said I was one of Hordak's failed experiments, but I… I remember things, sometimes."

Adora presses even closer to Catra. Soon enough she'll be buried in her fur. She just doesn't want Catra to run away. Catra is the best thing about the Fright Zone. "What do you remember?"

"Stuff," Catra says, and slowly, she twists around in Adora's hold. Her beautiful eyes meet Adora's, and she shrugs. "I might just be making it up. But sometimes I remember… a nice place. Big and open and outside, with fresh air and birds I can hunt. And… and a woman. With fur and ears and a tail just like me. She- she holds me and makes these sounds that- that make me feel better."

Catra's tail swishes, and Adora knows that it means she's happy. "Do you think she's your mom?"

"I don't know," Catra says, but she remembers something and her ears fold back in fright. "I'm not supposed to think about it. Especially not the sounds. I'm not supposed to act like an animal or Shadow Weaver will put me in a cage."

Adora grips her tighter when Catra lets out a frightened whimper. She remembers that day. She and Catra had been playing, and Adora jumped on her and tickled her. Catra let out soft little purrs between laughs, and Shadow Weaver had caught them.

"Remember, Catra," Shadow Weaver had said, smiling down at Catra in that cold, threatening way, "*if you refuse to act like a proper little girl, I will lock you in a cage with all of the other base creatures."*

Catra had been terrified, because sometimes she just does things. Adora knows that she can't control her purr, or her tail and her

ears, and sometimes when she wakes up she lets out a surprised chirp or a trill that she can't stop. She always looks so guilty after it, and Adora knows that she's scared of Shadow Weaver's threat. Catra hates closed spaces, hates feeling trapped.

"Shadow Weaver is just trying to get you to be a better cadet," Adora says, because that's why she does the things she does. "She won't really lock you in a cage."

Catra's tail flicks anxiously, and Adora knows she doesn't believe her. Adora isn't sure she believes herself. "I wish I was a person."

"You *are* a person," Adora whispers gently. She reaches forwards and scratches behind Catra's ears in that one spot she knows she likes. "You shouldn't listen to Shadow Weaver, or those other cadets. They're… they're a bunch of dumbfaces."

Adora gets a weird thrill when she realises she said something bad about Shadow Weaver. She never breaks the rules, *ever*, so it makes her feel like… like the biggest rebel there is. It's worth it for the tiny flicker of a smile on Catra's face too, and the way she leans into Adora's touch.

Only Adora is ever allowed to touch Catra's ears. It doesn't stop Shadow Weaver from grabbing her by one and dragging her away to be punished, or other cadets from pulling on them. But only Adora has actual permission to do it. Adora knows it's because Catra knows she would never do anything to hurt them. Everyone else in the Fright Zone is cold and cruel, but Adora always does her best to be kind.

Adora is the only one to ever treat *Catra* kindly.

"It's not just that," Catra scoots forwards, pressing closer to Adora, "it's you, too."

Adora tenses against her in surprise. Her grip on Catra loosens accidentally, and Catra shuffles forwards again, silently asking her not to let go. "Me? You said I didn't do anything wrong."

"You didn't," Catra mumbles, burying her face in Adora's shoulder. She hugs her tight, claws digging into Adora's shoulder blades. Adora winces, but she knows it's not Catra's fault. She still doesn't know how much her claws can hurt. "It's my fault."

Adora frowns. "That doesn't make any sense."

"They made fun of you," Catra mumbles into her shoulder. "They made fun of you because of me. Because you're friends with me."

Adora's frown goes away at the words. She was scared she'd done something wrong, because she never wants to upset Catra. They look out for each other. "Oh. I don't care if some dumb big kids want to laugh at me. One day, you and me are gonna call the shots around here. Then we can laugh at *them*."

Catra blinks at her. She can usually tell when people are lying – it's like she senses their dishonesty – and there's nothing there to sense and Adora knows she knows it. "You don't care? But… but I'm dragging you down. Like Shadow Weaver says. The big kids wouldn't laugh at you if you weren't friends with me."

"I want to be friends with you. I don't want to be friends with them." Adora says, because it's the most obvious thing in the world. Carefully, Catra bumps the top of her head against Adora's chin in a show of affection. Adora laughs, and a small hand runs through Catra's big mane. "And you're not dragging me down. You're my best friend. You're always gonna be my best friend."

"Even though…" Catra nuzzles into Adora's shoulder under the guise of affection, but Adora knows what she's really doing. Catra told her once, she nuzzles like that to leave her scent. She's marking Adora as *hers,* and Adora likes being Catra's. "Even though I'm the freak with the tail and the ears?"

"I like your tail, and your ears," Adora scratches behind one affectionately, "they make you special."

It's true. Catra is different from everybody else in the Horde, but that doesn't mean she's bad. And out of everyone, Adora likes the

way Catra looks the best. She doesn't know why that is, but she just does. Sometimes she looks at Catra, just watches her as she works, and she always thinks she looks pretty.

Catra doesn't look like she believes her, but her tail swishes happily and curls around Adora's foot before winding around her ankle and tethering them together.

"Okay," she says into Adora's shoulder, "and you're always gonna be my best friend too."

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3)

It's hard to forget the look on Catra's face as she disappeared into the smoke in Thaymor.

She looked so hurt. So betrayed.

Adora doesn't blame her for it. All of those promises they'd made when they were children, assuring each other it would just be the two of them at the end of the world, all broken in a day.

But Adora couldn't go back. She *couldn't*, not once she saw what the Horde was truly doing. She thought that Catra would come with her when she saw it too. Catra had even talked about wanting to defect when she was a child, and Adora thought that she'd help. She thought that she'd join the Rebellion, and that she wouldn't have to break her promises.

She thought wrong.

It's like it's all she can think about, though. It makes it even harder to settle into Bright Moon when she can't sleep. Every time she closes her eyes, she sees the look of betrayal on Catra's face, and snaps up in bed. Every time she does, without fail, she reaches for the foot of the bed, where Catra is supposed to be. Every time, her hand touches empty space.

She's usually okay at waking up quietly on bad nights. But after that day in the Crystal Castle, where Catra just left her hanging from that ledge, it's hard to stifle. Because that's another image that stays with her.

You've always been the one holding me back.

You wanted me to think I needed you.

You wanted me to feel weak.

Every hero needs a sidekick.

I wonder what I could've been if I'd gotten rid of you sooner.

She never meant to make Catra feel that way, but the words echo in her head, over and over again as she realises the reality. Shadow Weaver had always been harsher to Catra, but Adora always thought that it was because Catra was never as disciplined as she was. Even back when they started their cadet training, Catra would get distracted. Adora thought that it was just how things were.

And now her best friend is her mortal enemy.

The thought makes something in her chest crack wide open.

"Adora?" Bow asks when he hears her panicked breathing. He looks up from his sleeping bag as Adora shoots up in bed, blue and yellow eyes still burning with betrayal seared into the forefront her mind. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Adora mumbles, laying back down and rolling over. "It's fine. Go to sleep."

He wouldn't understand, Adora justifies. Bow and Glimmer have only ever known Catra as *Force Captain Catra.* They never met the scared little kitten who could never control her tail.

“You don’t sound fine,” Glimmer says tiredly as she sits up, “what’s wrong?”

You’ve always been the one holding me back. You wanted me to think I needed you. You wanted me to feel weak.

“Nothing’s wrong,” Adora pushes *her* voice from her head and pulls her covers up to her chin. “I’m fine. Go to sleep.”

“Adora,” her bed sinks under extra weight, and she feels Bow’s warm, calloused hand on her shoulder. “We’re the Best Friend Squad. We talk to each other when there’s something wrong. We won’t make fun of you.”

Glimmer hums in slight disagreement. “Well, we won’t make fun of you *much.*”

“Glimmer,” Bow warns, and she holds up her hands in surrender, “ignore her, Adora. What’s going on?”

“You *promise* you won’t make fun of me?” Adora asks, and they both nod in agreement. “Or… judge me, or anything?”

“We promise,” Glimmer says, clapping a hand to her chest. “Cross our hearts, hope to die.”

Adora squints at the both of them, searching for any falsehood, but she comes up short. Eventually, she sighs. What could go wrong if she tells them? It’s not like it matters anymore.

“I… I miss Catra,” Adora mumbles it quietly enough in the hopes that they don’t hear her. But they do, if the frown on Bow’s face and the confused and mildly disgusted look on Glimmer’s means anything. “I know you guys just know her as your enemy, but… she and I were really close, and before I met you, she… she was the only person I had. We made a promise that we’d always be there to look out for each other and I broke it.”

When she stops talking, the room is completely silent. Bow and Glimmer are both looking at her in what looks like bewilderment,

and that just makes *Adora* confused, because what's so puzzling about what she said?

"Were you guys, like… together?" Glimmer asks cautiously, and Adora looks up from the pillow she'd been examining in the hopes that her friends would just forget she ever said anything. "You can tell us."

"Together?" Adora frowns. She isn't sure what Glimmer is asking her. "Well… yeah. We grew up together."

"No, but…" Glimmer exchanges a look with Bow. It's that concerned *is Adora even a real person* look that she's come to know well. "I mean… were you in a relationship?"

"I don't know what you're asking me," Adora stares at them blankly. It's probably another weird thing she was never taught growing up. She's made a *lot* of discoveries about the world since joining the Rebellion. "What do you mean by relationship?"

"She doesn't know what a relationship is," Bow looks absolutely horrified as the realisation dawns on him, and strong arms wrap tightly around Adora in a hug. "I'm so sorry."

"I'm not upset," Adora says as she pulls out of the hug, because she's not. She's just confused. Relationship? Together? What does any of that mean? "Just… tell me what you meant."

"Well…" Glimmer pauses like she's trying to think of an easy way to explain the unfamiliar concept. "Okay. You know how my mom and my dad were married?"

Adora frowns even more. "What's married?"

"Oh, god," Glimmer mutters to herself, while Bow pulls Adora in for another sympathy hug, "this is going to take a lot longer than I thought."

"The more you talk about the Fright Zone, the more terrible it sounds," Bow says dramatically as Adora tries to pry him off of

her, “how did you stay there for so long?”

“I never knew anything different, I guess…” Adora trails off with a shrug. Distant memories of two little kids running through corridors and giggling between themselves come to the front of her mind as she murmurs, “It wasn’t all bad.”

“Okay, so,” Glimmer starts again, “a relationship is sort of like… where that person means more to you than anyone else. Your feelings for them are different to your feelings for other people. You’re in love with them.”

Adora’s stomach drops a little, because that sounds exactly how she always felt about Catra. “And… and what does that feel like?”

“You want to be around them all the time. You want to hold their hand, and hug them, and kiss them, and… other stuff,” Glimmer’s face flushes pink as she changes the subject, “you just want to be with them forever. And when they feel the same way about you, you’re in a relationship.”

“*Oh*,” Adora lets Glimmer’s words sink in. Is that what she and Catra were? They always promised each other they’d stick together and look out for each other. “So… like you guys?”

Bow and Glimmer both let out a stunned ‘*what*?’ and shake their heads a little too fast for Adora to believe them.

“No, uh,” Bow says, and he doesn’t look at Glimmer at all when he coughs and asks, “so… do you get what we mean?”

“I guess,” Adora says, even though she’s not sure at all. Were she and Catra together? They never kissed or did whatever *other stuff* was. Hugging wasn’t exactly a thing in the Fright Zone, when they got too old for it. Sometimes they held hands, but that was only if Adora was pulling Catra somewhere.

That doesn’t mean that Adora didn’t *want* to do those things. If she’d known that she could, anyway. But none of that matters

anymore. There's no going back. Catra had made that perfectly clear.

"I don't think that's what Catra and I had…" Adora says slowly, "she was just my best friend."

It feels like a lie. Adora hopes it doesn't sound like one.

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4)

Maybe it was stupid of her, to hold out hope for so many years.

It probably *was* stupid of her; everyone has always told her that she's more brawn than brain, but whatever.

Adora never gave up on Catra. Not properly. There was always some tiny part of her that hoped Catra would one day realise just how bad the Horde is. Adora had imagined hundreds of scenarios in her head as she laid restless in bed, still not used to sleeping without Catra's warmth right there with her.

Maybe something would happen in a battle, and Catra would switch sides. She'd jump in harm's way, shielding Adora from something, with a smirk and a cocky, "Hey, Adora."

Or maybe she'd just change her mind one day. That's the scenario Adora loves imagining best. That one day she'd wake up to find Catra at the edge of the Whispering Woods, just outside of Bright Moon.

Catra would smile at her the way she hasn't for years now, tail flicking behind her happily, because she wouldn't need to hide her natural instincts in Bright Moon. In Bright Moon, Catra could be *herself*. She could purr and chirp and trill, and Adora would even let her knead her stomach, as long as she promised to retract her claws first.

In a perfect world, Catra would be fighting by Adora's side.

Maybe that's why they're still together in the portal world.

Adora doesn't know if they're *together* in the way that Glimmer meant it, back when Adora first joined the Rebellion and opened up about it all. The lines are still blurry, like they always were in the *real* world, but it's different.

In the portal world, there's no hesitation when Catra pounces on her and locks their fingers together. In the portal world, there's no questioning glances when Catra walks into Adora's Force Captain bedroom like it's her own. In the portal world, it feels like they're *allowed* to be like that, in a way they've never been before.

Catra still doesn't go with her there, though.

"Why can't you just stay?" She asks Adora desperately as the world is breaking around them. "We have everything we ever wanted."

Up until then, Adora thought that this had been her own idea of a perfect world. A world where she had Catra the way she thinks she's always yearned for, and neither are afraid to show it.

But when Catra asks the question, Adora realises that it was never her perfect world. It was Catra's. She was the one who pulled the switch. She was the one who was so ensnared in rage and pain and hatred that she decided to take the whole world down with her.

There's still a little piece of Adora that aches for her. She pleads with her and hopes that if she manages to fix this mess, some part of the *real* Catra will hear it. "It's not real, Catra. As much as I wish that things could be simple the way they used to be, there's no going back."

But you can come with me, Adora wants to scream, *you've always been able to come with me.*

Catra rejects her again, refuses it, and Adora doesn't know if the rock she clings onto crumbles before or *after* she lets go. She

watches Catra fall, watches the girl she's always known die, and she realises that in a way, she already has.

It doesn't sink in until she comes back as this corrupted, hateful thing that Adora barely recognises. She hates that there's still a part of her that feels something, but Adora pushes it down and fights her.

A part of her will always ache for Catra, but not for *this.*

If the portal teaches Adora anything, it's that Catra will never go with her. It's that Catra is too far gone, and Adora will never have her the way she wants.

Because when Adora watches her pull that lever, the Catra in her head dies a death. The little kitten with scared eyes and ears too big for her head. The teenage girl who hates losing when they spar and makes dramatic comments about how she'll *totally get Adora next time.* The girl sleeping soundly at the foot of her bed that night when she crept out to find the sword and never went back. They're all dead and gone now.

Except Catra isn't. She's right there, but Adora doesn't know who she is anymore.

When Catra pulls that lever, Adora gives up.

In a way, it feels like mourning. That's what Castaspella calls the thing they're all feeling about Queen Angella. *Mourning*. What she feels for Catra, for the girl she used to know, feels exactly like that.

But how do you mourn somebody that isn't even dead?

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5)

When the Galactic Horde comes to Etheria, Adora works herself nearly to death.

Horde Prime has Glimmer, and she needs to get her back. She needs to save her.

Bow forces her to rest, but it's hard. There's so much on her mind, and Adora has never been the best at resting when there *isn't* something on her mind. Not since she left the Horde, and even sometimes before then. A tiny voice in the back of her mind keeps telling her that she's focusing so much on Glimmer because there's something else missing.

Someone else missing.

The someone else who has been the reason she hasn't had a good night's sleep since she turned against the Horde.

She's tossing and turning in her tent when Scorpia comes to bring her some food. Entrapta is bouncing along with her, babbling about some tech updates she's doing on Mara's ship, and how they'll be ready to take off soon enough. They'll be on their way to finding Glimmer, and *hopefully* on their way to somehow beating Horde Prime.

Adora sits up when Scorpia brings the tray in. She thanks her for the food, but as Scorpia and Entrapta are heading out again, she stops them. "Wait. Can I talk to you guys for a moment?"

It occurs to her that they're the only ones who can really understand what she's feeling, even if it's only just a little bit.

"What's wrong, Adora?" Scorpia asks, and then she narrows her eyes. "No, we're not telling you anything mission related. You need your rest."

"It's not that, it's just…" Adora swallows the lump in her throat. She knows that voicing things makes them somewhat tangible and *real*, but the little voice at the back of her mind won't stop bugging her. "Have either of you heard anything about Catra?"

Entrapta looks up from Bow's tracker pad – she's been making updates to it. "No. But she's probably still with the Horde,

considering that's where she was last time, and she made it quite clear that it's where her allegiances lie. Hope that helps!"

Adora watches as Entrapta speeds off back to the ship. Her stomach sinks. *Yeah,* Adora thinks to herself, *Catra's probably still with the Horde. And that's the* positive *reality.*

Scorpia shuffles awkwardly from foot to foot, and she speaks the words Adora dreads to speak herself. "You think she might be… dead?"

Adora bites down on her bottom lip and nods. "Yeah. It's just… it's not normal. For things to be so quiet. Catra- she's not exactly a *subtle* enemy. She's always got some big plot she likes to dangle over my head. But there's nothing."

"I think we'd know about it if she was," Scorpia says, but she doesn't sound all that sure, "she was Hordak's second-in-command, after all. If something happened to her, people would be talking about it. She's probably just laying low. Biding her time."

"Yeah," Adora says quietly, "probably."

Scorpia pauses on her way out of the tent. "You still… you still care about her?"

Adora stares down at the tray of food in her lap. She isn't sure. The last time she saw Catra, she was just angry. Angry at this hateful thing wearing her best friend's face. But there's still that weird ache in her chest, that *pull*, the one she isn't sure will ever go away.

"Honestly," Adora admits, "I think a part of me always will."

It's a part Adora has convinced herself she must bury. Catra is too far gone now; she made that clear when she opened the portal.

It's less clear when they're on their way to save Glimmer from Horde Prime's ship, and Adora hears *Catra* for the first time in

years. Not just Catra's voice, not Catra her enemy, but Catra, her best friend, the one who promised she'd always have Adora's back.

Catra sacrifices herself for Glimmer, and it sends Adora's thoughts spiralling again.

"*Adora, I'm sorry,"* it echoes in Adora's mind over and over again, *"for everything."*

The part of her that she thought she'd always have to bury bubbles to the surface. When Glimmer looks at her knowingly and says, "you want to go back for her," Adora doesn't hesitate to say yes.

She has to. If there's still some good left in Catra, Adora has to try. She has to try for the little kitten who always worried that her ears were too big, and who always helped Adora climb up to *their* ledge until Adora got big enough to make the climb herself.

//

They almost lose.

The whole time, she's never felt so terrified. Watching Catra fight like that. Watching Prime controlling her, making her hurt, *killing* her.

But none of it compares to when she's healing her, and that single, horrible moment when she thinks Catra isn't going to wake up.

She holds Catra's limp, lifeless body in her arms, and waits hopelessly for something she thinks isn't going to happen. But then Catra's chest moves in a cough, her eyes open and they're the beautiful blue and yellow that Adora has always loved, and she says softly, "Hey, Adora."

Adora has never felt relief like that. That aching feeling in her chest, the one that's been there for as long as she can remember,

finally fades into a soft happiness. It comes back the next day, but not for long. The last time Adora ever remembers feeling it is when she's walking away from her for what she thinks is the last time. But then Catra takes her hand and asks her to stay.

Finally, Adora *can* stay.

She knows that Bow and Glimmer are watching them, and Adora finds herself regretting that night she'd told them everything. She knows what they're thinking, but she doesn't know if *Catra* knows, and asking her would be so awkward and uncomfortable and Adora's never been good with the awkward stuff.

But she ignores the side-eyed looks they give her when she spends nights in Catra's cot with her, and she hopes Catra doesn't question it when they join the rest of the Rebellion and Adora's sword *accidentally* cuts her own bed into fifteen pieces.

Nothing ever goes Adora's way though. Catra asks immediately, when Adora casually clambers into bed with her. "Uh… personal space? Ever heard of it?"

"Sorry," Adora jumps up like she's been burned, "it's just- I was messing around with my sword and I maybe accidentally stabbed my bed a few times, and there's no others… I'll just go-"

"Come on, idiot," Catra pats the bed next to her, "We both know I'm the only one who can sleep through your sleep-fighting."

"Uh, only because you sleep like a rock," Adora rolls her eyes, but she can't hold back the grin on her face as she slips under the covers next to Catra. "I swear, Horde Prime could completely end the world and you'd sleep through it."

"I had to learn to sleep like a rock, or I never would've slept," Catra shoves her lightly, Adora shoves her back, and everything feels like it did all those years ago. "To be honest, I can't remember the last time I had a good night's sleep."

"Oh," Adora says, and slowly, carefully, fingers brush against Catra's under the covers. *You want to hold their hand, and hug them, and kiss them, and… other stuff,* Adora remembers. "Me too, actually. I never… I never really got the hang of sleeping alone."

I always missed you there, at the foot of the bed, or snoring on the top bunk, Adora thinks. She doesn't want to say it, because it might lead into something else, something she can't talk about right now.

Catra picks up on it anyway. "You saying you missed me?"

Adora lets out a scoff, but it's a lot more like a nervous laugh. "What? Of course not."

"You definitely missed me," Catra concludes from that reaction. Adora knows she's blushing, because she's so completely obvious, and she thinks she maybe always has been. "It's okay to admit it, Adora. I know I'm pretty much irresistible."

It's so strange, to hear her joking like that. Even Catra looks surprised as the words come out. Adora wonders when the last time she made a joke was. Had it been the time she was teasing Adora about the look of betrayal on her face during that last training session? Was that the last time Catra had ever been even a little bit carefree?

"I did, though," Adora mumbles embarrassedly, "miss you, I mean. Sometimes. I always missed the way things used to be. I tried not to think about it after the portal, because I didn't think I'd ever… I didn't think we'd be like this again. I thought you were too far gone. I'm sorry for that."

"I missed you too," Catra admits quietly, "when I wasn't trying to blame you for everything. And don't- don't apologise. I would've given up on me too."

"I guess we've got a lot we need to talk about, huh?" Adora questions out loud, and the fingers that are lightly brushing

against Catra's reach out to take her hand properly. Catra doesn't pull away, and there's a little spark of hope in her chest. "But I… I want to. If you do."

"I do."

"Oh," Adora's voice betrays her surprise, and she quickly tries to cover it up, "well. That's good. And… and I really appreciate that you're trying, you know?"

"I'm tired," Catra says, and Adora thinks she means literally until she keeps going, "tired of feeling so scared and angry and *alone* all the time. I don't want to push people away anymore. I want to be happy, and I'm willing to try for it. And for you. I promised you I'd always look out for you. It's time I started keeping that promise."

Adora feels that dip in her stomach, kind of like the one she gets when she's riding Swift Wind and he takes a big dive. But it's so much better than that. She doesn't know how to describe it yet.

"I think forever sounds nice with you," six-year-old Catra says nervously, looking over at Adora with the Fright Zone sprawling behind her.

"I want to keep my promise too," Adora says, squeezing Catra's hand under the covers. "You *do* owe me forever, after all. I want to make sure your reckless ass actually makes it there."

Catra scoffs, but it's soft and playful and it makes Adora's heart skip. "Shut the fuck up, you're way more reckless than I am."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Name *one* reckless thing I've ever done."

"Uh, infiltrating an evil alien overlord's spaceship to save your dumbass ex best friend who told you *not* to do exactly that?" Catra says, holding up a finger. "Pretty much everything you did on Krytis, and all of your other *let's blunder ahead into the unknown* plans. Oh, how about sneaking out in the middle of the

night and deciding *hey, I want to be a princess, let's join a Rebellion*-"

"Alright, I don't need my life story, I was there," Adora grabs Catra's other hand with her free one, and for a moment, she just looks at her, taking in how beautiful she is. But Adora knows she can't do anything about it yet. Not until this Horde Prime thing is taken care of.

Still, she'd be lying if she said she didn't want to lean over and kiss Catra right now. And maybe she's always wanted to do exactly that. All those nights in the barracks when they stayed up whispering about anything and everything, and giggling as they played pranks on Kyle in his sleep. She wanted to do it then, but she didn't know why. Even sometimes in battle, when Catra would look at her with that fucking *smirk*, all Adora would want to do is lean forwards and kiss it right off.

She almost does it. Almost forgets everything going on. But then Melog pounces on her and licks a stripe up her cheek affectionately, and the spell is broken.

Adora knows she can't, and she shouldn't. It wouldn't be fair to Catra right now, not when she's trying to heal. Adora can't just be *Adora* for her. Right now, the world needs She-Ra, not Adora and all of her messy girl problems.

After the war. She'll have plenty of time to sort through her feelings after the war.

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6)

Over the years, Adora has met many different versions of Catra.

The tiny, scared kitten. The teenager who always felt second best. The intimidating Force Captain. The broken villain hellbent on destroying herself and taking everyone else down with her. The melancholic girl trying her best to heal and recover and rebuild.

Adora has loved them all.

She knows that now. Adora has always loved Catra, even when she was at her worst. She'd carried that feeling around her whole life, an ache in her chest, like she'd left a part of her heart with Catra the day she met the confused, scared kitten in that falling-apart old box, and it was always trying to pull her back.

Slowly, Adora meets another Catra as they settle into their life in Bright Moon.

Adora can't pinpoint where she goes from the girl trying to be better to the genuinely happy woman she sees in front of her every day. It's not like one day she just woke up and she was fine. Sometimes Adora still sees flashes of someone trying to recover. But mostly, Catra has healed.

She's not afraid anymore. That's the thing Adora notices first.

At first, Catra is reproachful in their new home. She doesn't seem like she knows what to do, where to go. Glimmer appoints her the Queen's Advisor because she's – quote – "sick of watching Catra mope around like a sad little kitten all the time," and that's what helps her settle, Adora thinks.

It gives her a purpose, anyway, outside of trying to mend personal relationships with people. But she's still trying with that.

Adora catches little things as the months go by. Things that make her heart swell with pride.

As they start rebuilding, Adora goes to find Bow in the castle. His trick arrows have come in handy, and Glimmer tells Adora to ask Bow to make more, with certain specifications that she doesn't entirely understand.

She gets to his room with her mission firmly in mind, but Adora pauses by the door when she hears voices.

"And what does this one do?"

“It’s a sonic arrow.”

“A sonic arrow?” Catra asks dryly. “That’s the dumbest thing I’ve ever heard.”

“Hey, don’t diss the sonic arrow,” Bow says, and Adora watches from the door as he snatches it back, “that thing saved our lives once.”

“Oh, yeah?” Catra snorts with laughter. “I don’t believe that for a second.”

“It was when Entrapta’s robots went all murdery,” Bow says, “that was the first time we met her, actually. It was a *real* first impression.”

“So, her robots tried to kill you, and you still invited her into your little princess gang?” Catra raises her eyebrows, picking up another arrow and examining it. “Honestly, it would’ve been so easy to beat you guys if I just showed up and pretended to be all buddy-buddy with you.”

“Nobody would’ve believed that,” Bow says, “because the first time I spent more than thirty seconds around you, you literally pushed me off a cliff. There’s no way you could’ve pretended for long enough to actually accomplish something. You’d have lost it and tried to kill at least one of us within a day.”

“I don’t know,” Catra puts the arrow down with a grin, “haven’t slipped so far.”

Bow pauses in the middle of sharpening an arrow tip. “Very funny. I know you like us.”

Catra snorts. “I’m offended by that horrible accusation. Why would I like a bunch of sparkly idiots?”

Melog betrays her completely; they have a habit of doing that, and it’s something Adora appreciates them for. Melog won’t let Catra run from her feelings. They jump up to lick Bow’s cheek,

and he smiles smugly at Catra. “Thank you, Melog, for your amazing timing.”

Catra rolls her eyes. “Shut up.”

“Seriously, though,” Bow says, “it’s okay for you to open up here. Nobody’s going to judge you for anything. We’re friends.”

Catra pauses, and slowly, she takes the seat next to him instead of standing on the opposite side of the table. “Seriously?”

“Yeah,” Bow smiles, “let me tell you something. Growing up, I used to play princesses *all* the time. My brothers always made fun of me, because it wasn’t a ‘guy’ thing to do, but I still did it anyway, because it was fun and I liked it.”

Catra is quiet for a while, like she seriously has to think about what she wants to say. Adora almost laughs and outs herself as an eavesdropper when Catra says, deathly serious, like she’s admitting some deep, dark secret, “I like getting my ears scratched.”

Bow puts down the arrow he’s working on and smiles. “Do you want me to scratch your ears?”

“Don’t hurt them,” Catra says instead of *yes*, and Adora is taken back years, gets flashes of older cadets pulling on Catra’s ears, teasing her with a mocking *here, kitty kitty* as a way to make fun of her for being different. That’s when Adora realises how big of a step this is. How much trust Catra is putting into Bow.

In that moment, she’s never felt prouder.

“I won’t hurt them,” Bow promises, and slowly, his hand reaches out and scratches behind Catra’s left ear. “Is this okay?”

Catra doesn’t respond with anything other than a nod. Slowly, her beautiful eyes start to close, and a sound Adora even now rarely gets to hear begins to rumble in Catra’s chest.

“Hold on a second,” Bow’s hand pauses as he rubs behind Catra’s ear. “You can *purr*?”

Catra’s eyes snap open in a glare. “I will leave *right now.*”

“Okay, okay, sorry,” Bow says with a laugh, “it’s cute though.”

“For the *millionth* time, I’m not cute,” Catra scowls, but Adora has to agree with Bow on this one. Catra holds up her hand and protracts her claws for proof. “You see these claws? Are *they* cute?”

“Nope, they’re pretty terrifying,” Bow says, “you’re very scary, Catra. Now shut up and let me pet you like you wanted.”

“Okay,” Catra says, and she lightly rests her head on his shoulder. “If you tell anyone about this, I *will* murder you.”

Bow laughs. “I totally believe that.”

Slowly, Adora backs away and leaves them to it. She knows how Catra will react if she makes a big deal about it – she’ll freak out, close herself off and probably never make a big step like this again, and that’s the last thing Adora wants. She turns away and lets her girlfriend make that progress on her own.

At least until she gets back to the meeting and Glimmer yells at her for forgetting the one thing she told her to and get, and she has to go back and interrupt them anyway.

Adora expects Catra to jump away from Bow like she totally wasn’t getting her ears scratched, but instead, she just flashes a sleepy smile, lets out a tired little trill and curls her tail around Adora’s wrist affectionately as she explains to Bow all of the arrows Glimmer wants.

//

About three months into rebuilding, Adora hears Catra’s voice echoing from the gardens. At first, she assumes she’s just talking

to Melog; she does that sometimes, and even though Adora knows that Catra understands Melog's vocalisations because of their emotional bond, it's still funny to watch.

"Daisies," Catra scoffs, and Adora pauses in her tracks, "what a fucking psychopath."

Adora heads towards the big ornate doors out to the gardens. She likes it when she runs into Catra and Melog around the castle. She pauses and ducks around to hide when she sees something entirely unexpected – Catra and *Glimmer.*

"We can burn them, if you want," Glimmer says, and Adora almost jumps in then, because Catra, plus Glimmer, plus fire doesn't sound like the best combination. "Her whole weird, evil garden."

Catra laughs. It's not her dry, sarcastic laugh, but her real one, the one that's so soft and musical. "Murdering flowers? Not very *princessy* of you, Sparkles."

"Good thing I'm a queen, then," Glimmer retorts, and Adora watches in complete surprise when Glimmer puts a hand on Catra's shoulder and Catra doesn't immediately jump away. "I'm serious, though. We can get rid of her whole garden. I'm sure Perfuma can make something better in like, literal seconds."

"She has more important things to do," Catra says quietly, "it's fine."

The hand on Catra's shoulder moves around to pull her in for a hug. Catra hesitates, but lets her arms wrap around Glimmer in return, and when they pull away, there's this tiny smile on Catra's face that makes Adora's heart stutter in her chest.

"Adora told me how Shadow Weaver treated both of you," Glimmer says seriously, "I know she's gone now, and I know it's just a stupid flower garden. But even a tiny reminder of the woman who abused you both for years can cause a lot of pain. It's okay to be not okay sometimes. We'll burn the garden. You and me."

Catra is silent for a few moments, but Adora hears the meaning in it. She thinks Glimmer does too. "I don't think Adora and Arrow Boy are going to let us play with fire."

"Well…" Glimmer pauses, "what they don't know won't hurt them."

"You know what, Sparkles?" Catra says, "You're a *lot* more badass than I thought you'd be."

Glimmer grins. "I've been told."

"And…" Catra pauses, and Adora hears the quiet tremor in her voice, "thanks. I don't really… know how to thank people, so… yeah. I owe you one."

"Forget about it," Glimmer says, nudging her lightly, "friends help each other out."

Adora turns away from the garden with a soft smile on her face. And, of course, plans to tell Bow that their respective girlfriends are planning to have a bonfire with Shadow Weaver's flower garden.

Because Catra, Glimmer and fire really would be a disastrous combination.

//

The second time Catra opens a portal, the only people who know about it until after the fact are Scorpia and Entrapta, who she apparently swore to total secrecy.

Adora has no idea why she told *Scorpia*, because despite what she says, she's not the best with secrets. But this one is one she manages to keep. Even from Adora – when she asks where Catra's been going lately, Scorpia manages a hurried excuse of *Super Pal Trio hangouts* before she escapes.

For a while, Adora barely sees Catra. They wake up together, Catra kisses her good morning, hurriedly gets ready and then

‘goes to Dryl’. While she appreciates that Catra is making an effort with Scorpia and Entrapta, she misses her girlfriend and wonders why she’s being so secretive about whatever she’s doing.

Adora asks her if she can go with one day, and she has to say that she never thought she’d hear Catra say the words, “Super Pal Trio only, sorry,” in her lifetime.

She doesn’t understand any of it, until one day, when in the middle of one of Glimmer and Micah’s court sessions, the door bursts open and Catra, Scorpia and Entrapta show up. Entrapta is doing some tech thing on a tracker pad she’d made, and Scorpia and Catra are carrying something between them.

It’s like everyone in the whole room realises what they’re carrying at the exact same time.

Or more accurately, *who* they’re carrying.

Glimmer stands up from her throne, her eyes widening in shock. “*Mom*?”

Queen Angella raises her head, as Glimmer runs the length of the throne room like she doesn’t believe it’s real. Adora can’t believe her eyes. How could this be possible? How did it happen? Is this why Catra was being so secretive?

“Glimmer,” Angella’s voice is scratchy from lack of use, and she sounds so, so tired. But it doesn’t last long when she sees the other person rushing from the thrones. “*Micah*?”

“Angie,” Micah says like he can’t believe his eyes, “you’re here… how…?”

Scorpia and Catra help Angella stand for her family to take her weight and pull her in for a hug. Glimmer’s voice is muffled in her parents’ tight embrace as she mumbles shakily, “I never thought I’d see you again,” and Bow quietly dismisses the rest of the court to let them have their moment of privacy.

Adora catches up to Catra as the throne room doors close behind Glimmer and her parents and their tearful family reunion. She stares at her girlfriend, studying her, trying to think of which question she wants to ask first. All she manages to get out in her surprise is, "*how*?"

Catra pauses and pulls Adora aside. "We're not in despondos anymore. And I started thinking. That was reason Etheria didn't have portal capabilities and why that last one was so unstable, but now that's back online… I thought maybe there'd be a chance to make it right and save her. I talked to Entrapta about it, and through all of the science crap she threw at me, I figured it would be pretty risky, but it was possible."

"And…" Adora frowns, "why didn't you tell anyone except Scorpia and Entrapta?"

"I needed Entrapta for the tech, and Scorpia for the muscle, and there's no best friend bonding like one last dangerous mission together," Catra says, with a roll of her eyes, like she hadn't just saved the queen from being trapped between realities. "I didn't tell anyone else, because I didn't want to get anyone's hopes up. It might not have worked out. It was better that nobody knew, because if we tried and failed, then Sparkles and Micah would've had to mourn her all over again."

Adora pulls Catra in for a tight hug and hopes that it communicates everything she's feeling. "You're so- I'm so proud of you."

"This isn't about me," Catra says into her shoulder, "it's about them. It was my fault she ended up there in the first place. I just wanted to make it right. Besides, I owed Sparkles after she set the entire garden on fire just because Shadow Weaver's daisies were pissing me off."

"That's why I'm proud. You're doing all of these good things on your own." Adora smiles, letting Catra go. "And honestly, I think

Glimmer set the garden on fire because she thought it'd be fun, so I don't think you owed her for that at all."

//

Adora doesn't know why her brain won't shut up about Catra, but it makes it hard to sleep. Even though Catra is right there in bed next to her, snoring lightly, her face buried in the crook of Adora's neck.

But she can't stop thinking about her. All of her, every single version of Catra she's met across her life so far, and how she's so completely in love with all of them.

Don't you get it? I love you! I always have.

The more Adora thinks about it, the more she understands. Not just that she's always loved Catra, but that Catra has always loved her.

"I think forever sounds nice with you," six-year-old Catra says with a shy smile, ears folded back nervously as the Fright Zone creaks and groans behind her.

"You're always gonna be my best friend," eight-year-old Catra says, curling her tail around Adora's ankle.

"Were you guys like, together?" Glimmer asks the moment Adora gives even a little information about her feelings for Catra, and how much it hurt to leave her behind.

"Everything is perfect," says Catra in the portal, when they still have each other and it's not weird that they're so close. "Why can't you just stay? We have everything we ever wanted."

"I want to be happy, and I'm willing to try for it. And for you. I promised you I'd always look out for you. It's time I started keeping that promise," twenty-one-year-old Catra says, short haired and nervous and trying to make things right.

“When did you know?”

Adora hadn’t planned on vocalising her thoughts, but it happens anyway. Sometimes she’s like that.

Twenty-five-year-old Catra nuzzles into her shoulder, tiredly scent marking her as she yawns and asks, “know what?”

Adora lets her hand brush through Catra’s hair. It’s long again, but these days she keeps it up in a messy ponytail. She says she got the idea from Adora, but she didn’t think the ‘*dumb little hair poof’* would suit her. “When did you know you loved me?”

“I don’t know,” Catra says. She shifts in Adora’s arms and pushes herself up onto her elbows, blue and yellow eyes gazing down at her softly. “I think a part of me always knew. Even if I didn’t know what those feelings meant, they were always there.”

“It was the same thing for me,” Adora tells her, and Catra smiles, fang poking out against her bottom lip. Adora pushes herself up to kiss her. Sometimes, it still blows her mind that she can just *do* that and it’s normal. “It was like I gave you a piece of my heart when we met, and that was it. It was just a fact that I felt differently about you. That *you* meant more to me.”

Catra lays back down again, an arm resting over Adora’s stomach as she nuzzles into her. “I told you how I felt when we were kids. I didn’t realise what it meant, but I just knew I wanted to be with you forever.”

“Me too,” Adora says, and she wonders why the hell it took so damn long for them to keep that promise. “Sometimes… back when we were fighting, sometimes I’d wish that you came with me when I went to find the sword. Maybe you would’ve defected with me, if you’d been there. And I always imagined all of these scenarios where one day you’d just come and join the Rebellion and we’d be happy.”

“Turns out all you needed to do was let me get a little dead first,” Catra says dryly, and Adora lets out a shaky breath. Four years,

and she still can't think about that, how she'd felt Catra take her last breaths, how she'd *died* in Adora's arms. Catra seems to sense her anguish, because she nuzzles into her shoulder again. "Sorry. I shouldn't joke about that."

"It's okay," Adora squeezes her around the waist and pulls her closer, if that's even possible. "*You're* okay."

"More than okay," Catra looks up and flashes her a soft smile, "come on, Adora, I'm tough. It's going to take a lot more than falling off some stupid ledge and getting electrocuted to take me out."

"I'm just… I'm happy I don't have to worry about you like that anymore," Adora sits up, her hand cupping Catra's jaw, tracing across the freckles on her cheek. "I always did. And I always held back when we were fighting. I don't know what I would've done if I actually hurt you."

Catra pauses, and a hand comes up to grip Adora's wrist, pulling it away from her face. "Wait. You're telling me that every time I kicked She-Ra's ass, that was you *holding back*?"

"Yeah," Adora says, "obviously."

"*Obviously*," Catra scoffs, pushing their duvet off and getting up out of bed. "*Obviously* my fucking ass. We're going down to the gym and we're fucking sparring. I'll show you who's the powerful one here. Hurry up, we've got to make this quick, because Finn always comes and jumps on us at an *ungodly* hour of the morning."

Adora watches as Catra gets dressed in a huff, muttering to herself about *pride* and *victories*, with a fond smile on her face and a flutter in her chest.

Adora has loved every single version of Catra. But she thinks that this one, this beautiful, unafraid, loving, and genuinely *happy* Catra is her favourite.

End Notes

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